



Visual Basic Programming

An Introduction

Why Visual Basic?

- ★ Programming for the Windows User Interface is extremely complicated.
- ★ Other Graphical User Interfaces (GUI) are no better.
- ★ Visual Basic provides a convenient method for building user interfaces.
- ★ Visual Basic can interface with code written in C, for efficiency.



What Visual Basic is not

- ★ Visual Basic is *not*, a powerful programming language that enables you to do anything you want.
- ★ Visual Basic is *not*, elegant or fast.
- ★ Visual Basic is *not*, a replacement for C.
- ★ Visual Basic is *not*, anything like any other programming language you have ever used.



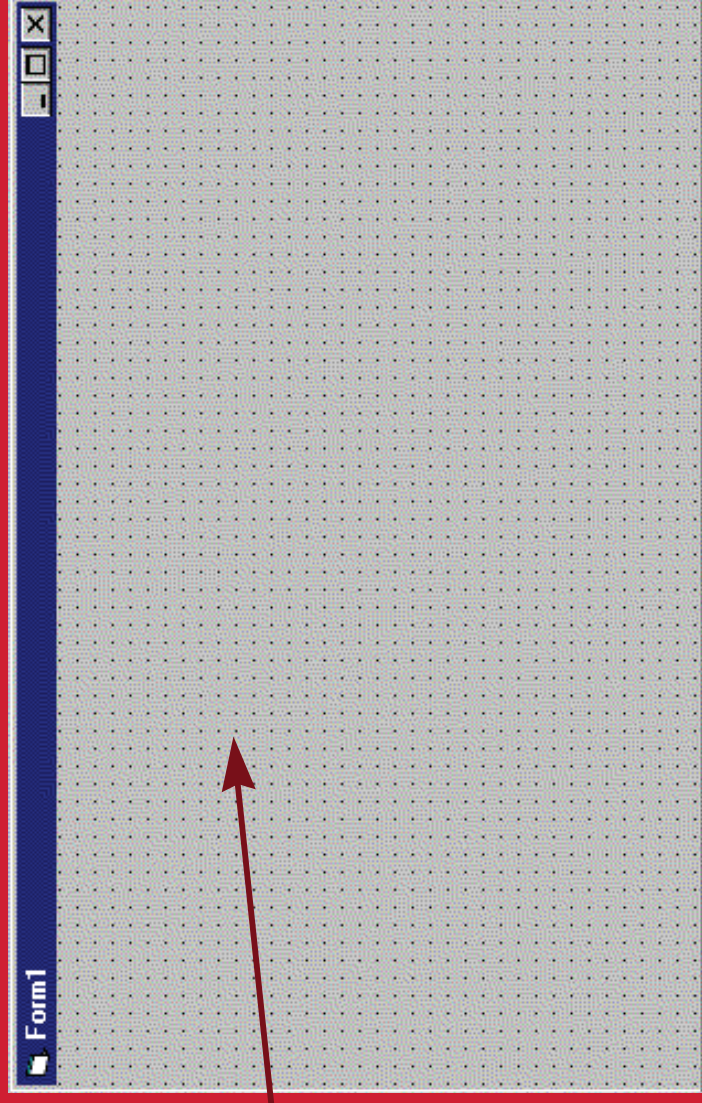
When You Program in VB:

- ★ You draw pictures of your user interface.
- ★ You draw buttons, text boxes, and other user-interface items.
- ★ You add little snippets of code to handle the user interaction.
- ★ You add initialization code, usually as the last step.
- ★ If you like, you can code more complex functions. (But many do not.)



The Visual Basic Interface

Draw Your
Program
Here!



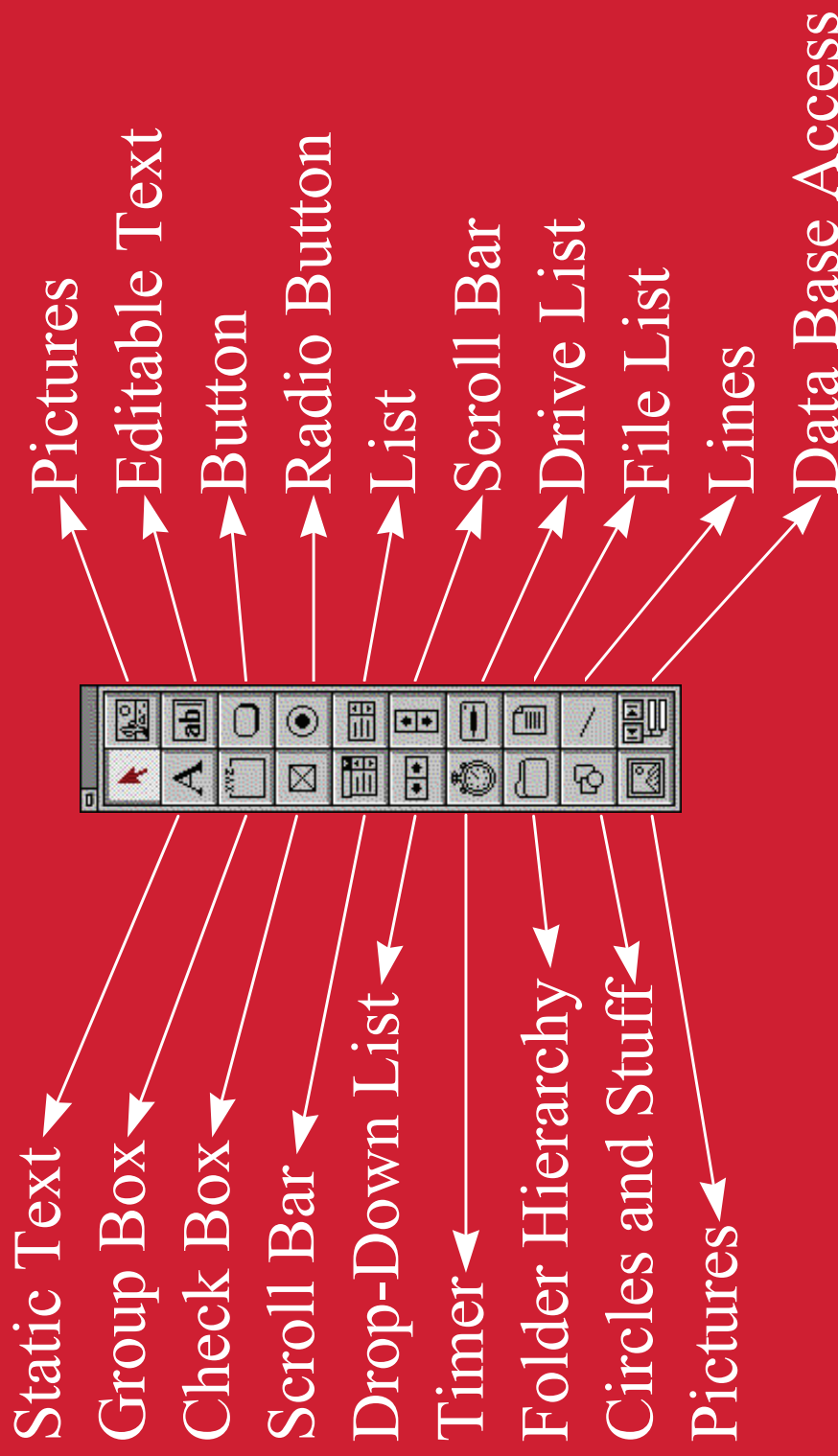
Drawing The Program

Select A Control From Here
(Click on the appropriate button)



Then Draw the control on the form

Types of Controls

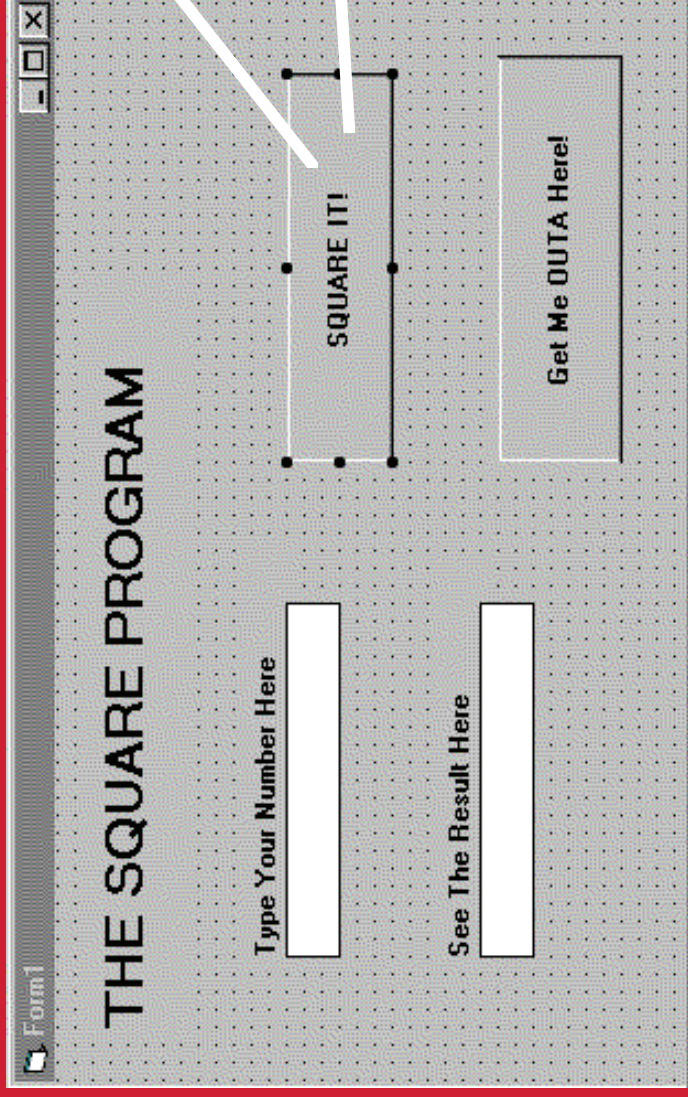


And the List Goes On and On ...

A Simple Program

Double-Click to
Add Code

Single-Click to
Select and
Change
Properties

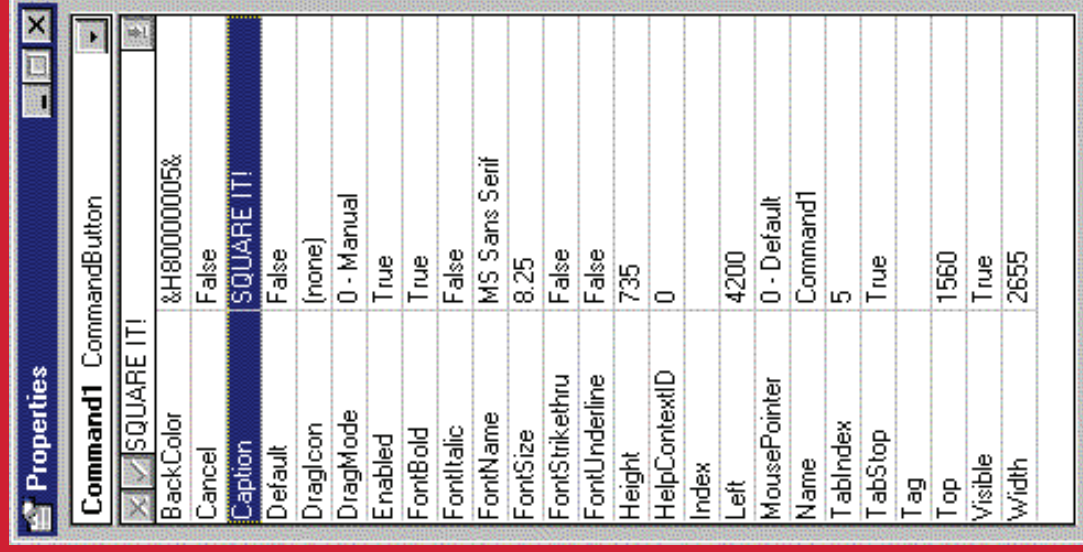


Using controls: Static Text
Editable Text
Buttons

The Properties Window

List of Properties
For Currently Selected
Control

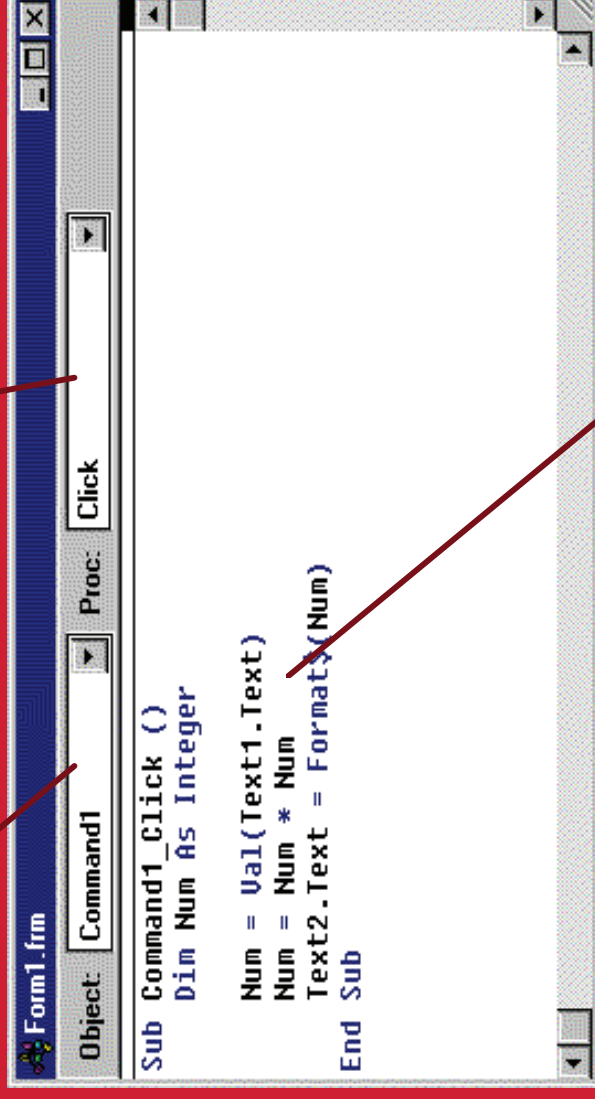
Click on Property, and
Type In New Value, or
Select New Value From
Menu.



Adding Code

Control
Name

External Event
Name



You must Write
The Body
Yourself

What to Do When It Happens

More Complex Controls

★ Complex Controls Have:

- *Action* Properties to Execute Commands
- *Active* Properties that Cause Actions When Values Are Assigned to Them
- Many Types of Events for Program Interaction

★ Examples:

- Spreadsheets
- Word Processors
- Web Browsers





Using C Code

- ★ Write a DLL in C
- ★ Use the _export Property on Appropriate Functions
- ★ Write Visual Basic Definitions for each Function
- ★ Add VB Definitions to The *(general)* section of the VB Program
- ★ Use Functions as if they were VB functions

C Definition vs. VB Definition

C:

`long FAR PASCAL _export HexToLong (char *Hex)`

VB:

Declare Function *HexToLong* Lib "FIRSTONE.DLL"
(ByVal *InString* As String) As Long

Function Name Must Be The Same in Both Declarations.
The Lib keyword Must Give The Name of the Library.
Argument Name in VB is arbitrary.

A (Very Annoying) Problem

- ★ It is sometimes difficult for VB to *FIND* the .DLL file.
- ★ If this occurs, copy the .DLL file to the WINDOWS directory.
- ★ Remember to Delete the file when you are done.



Alternative Methods

- ★ Some Versions of VB do not allow DLL function definitions in the (*general*) section of a form.
- ★ To Get Around this Problem, Create a new Module (File Menu)
- ★ Add the declarations to the (*general*) section of the module
- ★ You can add your own VB functions to the (*general*) section of a form or a module.



Syntax Considerations

- ★ All Functions are Global in VB
- ★ Variables are declared using the syntax:
 - Dim <Name> As <Type>
 - Every variable must have a type
 - Dim A,B,C As <Type> will work, but gives weird results
- ★ Most Common Types: Integer, String, Long



More VB Syntax

- ★ Use Integers for Booleans

- As in C, 0 = False, everything else = True
- Symbolic constants True and False may be used
- True = -1, False = 0

- ★ Assignments are the same as in C

- ★ The Val function converts strings to integers

- ★ The Format\$ function converts integers to strings



VB Statements

- ★ Assignments are the Same as in C
- ★ Case is not significant
 - Case will be adjusted for you on keywords
 - For Variable Names, Case is ignored
- ★ The Usual Operators can be used
 - AND is the same as both & and && depending on context
 - OR = | and ||
 - NOT = !



VB IF Statements

```
If <condition> Then  
    <List of Statements>  
Else  
    <List of Statements>  
EndIf
```

```
If <condition> Then  
    <List of Statements>  
EndIf
```

Comparators: =, <, >, <=, >=, < > (not equal)

Connectives: And, Or, Not

DON'T FORGET THE ENDIF!

VB While Statements

```
While <condition> do  
    <List of Statements>  
Wend
```

The VB Manual Recommends a different structure.
Use the alternative if you wish.



VB For Statements

```
For <Variable> = <start> to <finish>  
    <List of Statements>  
Next <Variable>
```

```
For <Variable> = <start> to <finish> Step <increment>  
    <List of Statements>  
Next <Variable>
```

Example:

```
For I = 1 to 10 do  
    A[I] = A[I] + 1  
Next I
```



VB Arrays

- ★ Indices Always Start With Zero
- ★ *Dim A[10] As Integer* Declares 11 elements, indexed from 0 through 10.
- ★ Multi-Dimensional Arrays are Permitted.
- ★ Arrays can be resized at run time (See VB Help File for *ReDim*)

VB Strings

- ★ Variable Length
- ★ Compare using standard comparators
- ★ Maximum length is about 64Kb
- ★ Minimum length is zero
- ★ Allocated from VB “String Space”, so may run out of space even on systems with much memory.



And in Conclusion ...

Go
Have
Fun!

